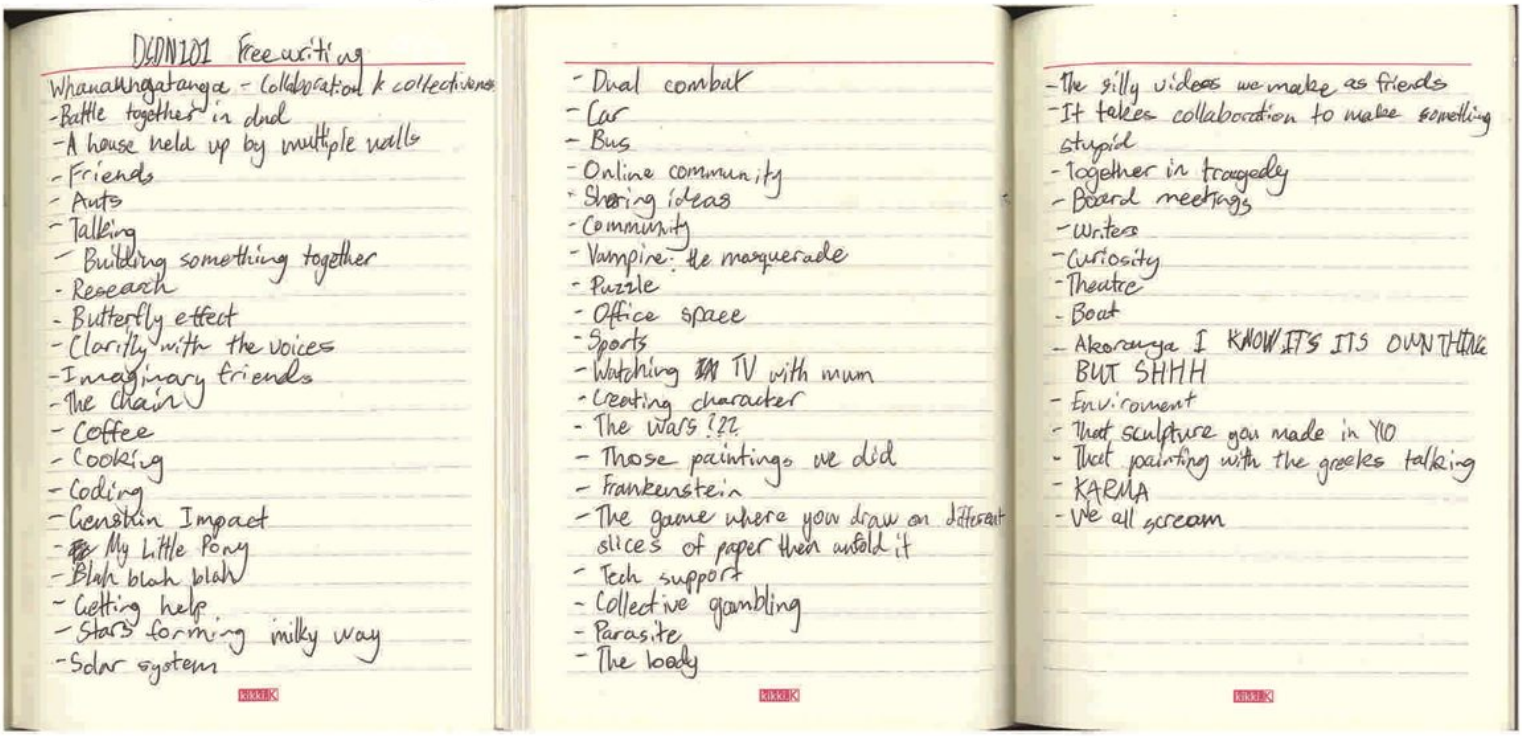
Collaborate with Nature

Workbook

Chosen value - Whanaungatanga:

I decided to have my VUW value for this project be Whanaungatanga, which is about collaboration and collectiveness.

Freewriting:



I noticed while doing my freewriting that I was very strongly focusing on the collaborative aspect of Whanaungatanga, so when it came time to begin sketching, I kept that idea of teamwork in mind.

Early sketches:

Early on, I was leaning into the idea of teamwork, or multiple elements working together to create a solution or something similar. However, I was struggling a lot because though they did work with the idea of collaboration, none of the ideas felt quite right for further creating, but I then remembered the Honeyguide bird. The Honeyguide has an ancient, collaborative relationship with humanity (Rossi, 2026), and I remember feeling rather joyful when I learned about this, so I decided to try this idea out and tag it 'Collaboration is ancient'. I ended up really liking this idea, and decided that I wanted to take this idea and work with it for my final design.





Target Audeince:

I am going to have my target audience be young adults of any gender, race, occupation, etc. I feel like this is the best group to target this to because young adults tend to get swamped with a lot of depressing news about the current state of the world so they end up feeling hopeless, especially as they kinda bear the burden of all of this news and have to process that this is the future being handed to them. **I want to break this sad news up a bit with a poster that shows that we do have ways to work with nature, hopefully bringing a bit of joy/hope amidst everything.** There is not many specifics beyond young adult as I think this message can be a nice message for any young adult. The only other thing I can think of is some reading comprehension as I do want to make this slightly educational so I would hope my audience has good literacy skills. **Considering this is meant to be a break from all the depressing stuff, I think an illustrative style would be appealing to young adults as it's a bit of a breath of fresh air from more industrial looks. I will also be aiming for an overall warmer look, both so it feels nicer but also because since we are entering a colder month it might be more effective to have the poster feel warm (Massey, 2018).**

Searching for inspiration:

The Honeyguide & Humans:

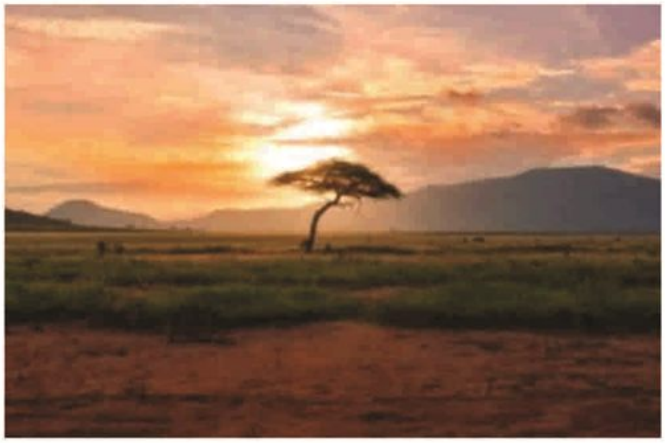








Location (Sub-Saharan Africa):





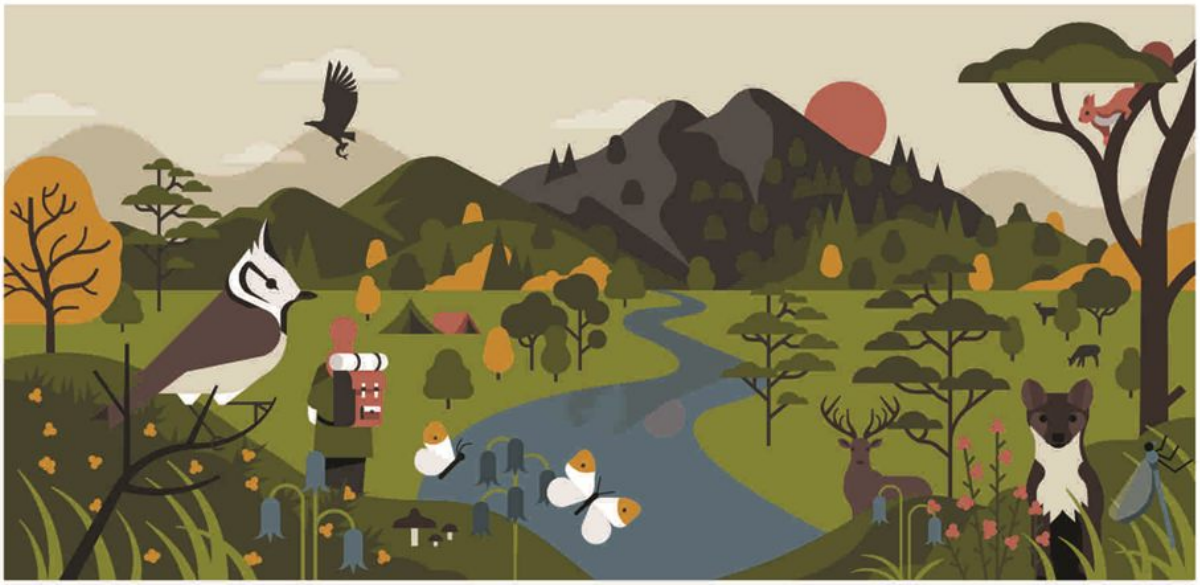
I'm beggining my search by looking at the location that the Honeyguide is primarily native to, which is Sub-Saharan Africa, and getting a clearer visualization of the connection between humans and the Honeyguide. **I quite like how joyful the people were when the Honeyguide was perched on their hand, so I want to see if I can incorporate this joy into my poster.** I also really like the image of the man following the Honeyguide, I think it shows this relationship in action very well.

I will also breifly clarify the collaborative relationship of the human and the Honeyguide:

The Honeyguide will perch on a branch and make a unique call specific to humans to tell them to follow. The bird will then fly ahead and make the call again and the humans will follow. This continues until a beehive is reached, and then humans access the hive using smoke and tools. The humans get the honey, and the beeswax and larvae is given to the Honeyguide (Rossi, 2026).

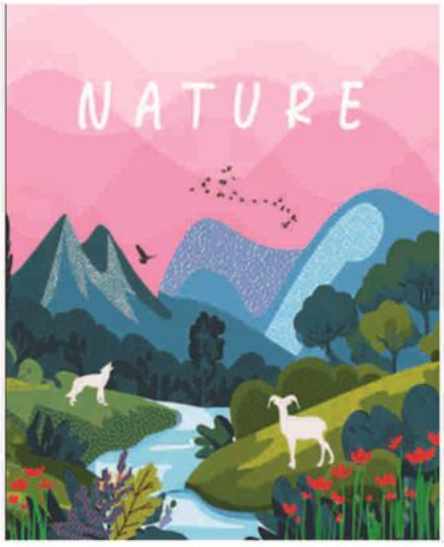
Searching for inspiration:

Reputable designer - Ed Harrison:



I quite liked how this designer's colours and all the elements worked very well and harmoniously. I wanted to find ways to use this more in my works.

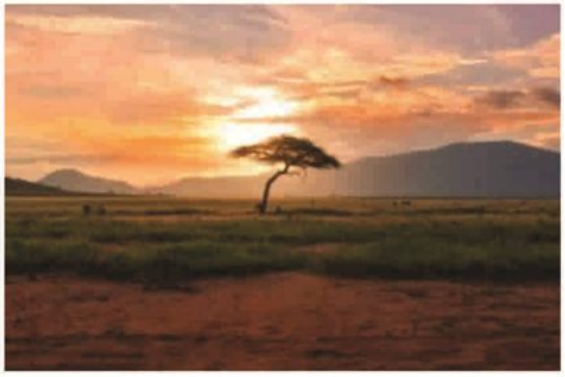
Google search for posters about nature:







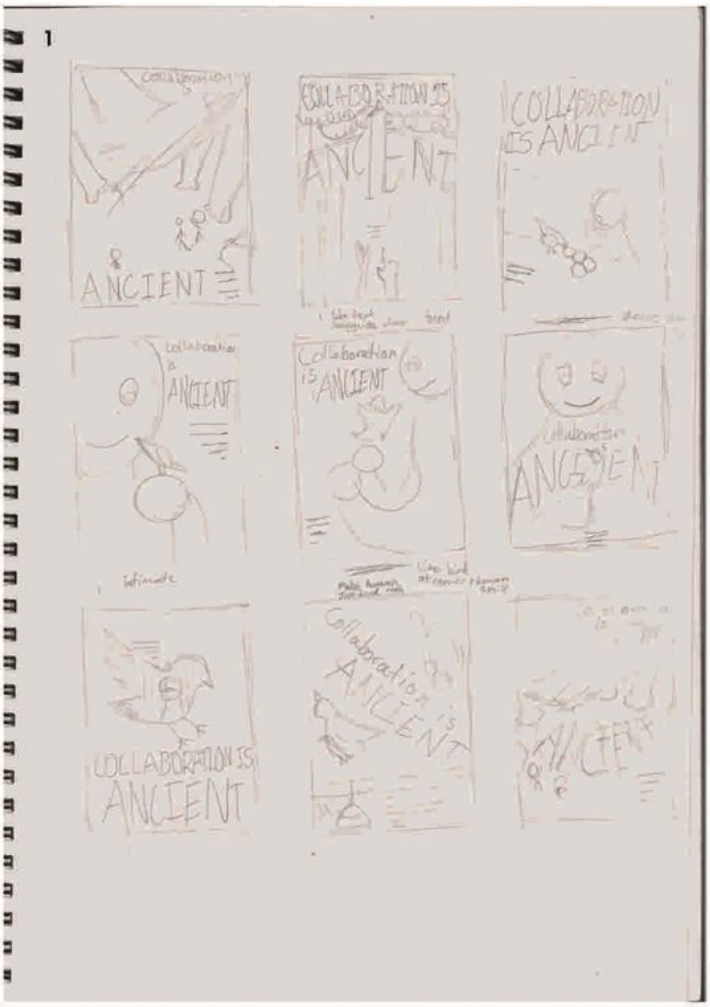
While the posters didn't quite give me what I was looking for, they did show me a rather whimsical nature that I wanted to see if I could put in my poster. The only issue is this is more forest-style nature in the way we think of a forest (more European), but the setting I envisioned was more Savanna. However, they did give me food for thought.





Previous PBA work.

First iterations:



I began by sketching out different ideas, varying from showing the relationship's connection (inspired by the pictures of the people holding the Honeyguide) to trying to show the collaboration between the Honeyguide and Humanity. I showed this first page of sketches to some family members, who really **liked the intimacy and joy of the human and the bird,** with my dad liking the text in the top middle sketch as it kind of sat on the bird and the trees. But my brother pointed out that **the actual collaboration of the person and the bird wasn't incredibly obvious and instead just felt like a cute interaction and not much more.** He suggested trying to incorporate something like the two giving each other something like in the top right.

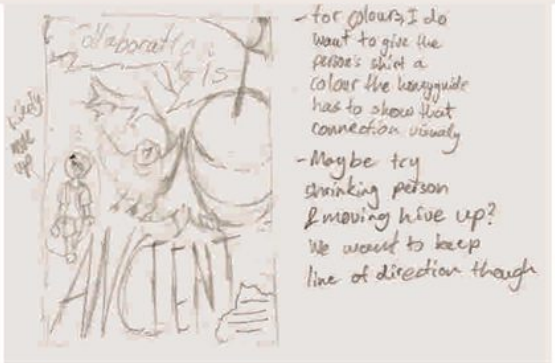
I personally really liked the warping perspective of the top left and bottom right the best, as it felt dynamic and visually interesting, so I really wanted to find a way to try to incorporate that into my poster.

Upon getting the feedback from my family I started sketching a few more ideas, shown on the second page. **I kept iterating with the bird-human intimacy ones and tried to incorporate the giving between the human and the bird while also trying to maintain the clarity of the location.** However, it felt like **it still didn't emphazise the collaboration as much as it just showed the end result. I wanted the collaboration to be very clear,** so I discussed this issue I was having with my tutor. My tutor recommended showing the beehive and making it clear the bird was guiding the person to the beehive, and to maybe forget making it perfectly accurate to how the relationship manifests in reality as it would struggle to be shown visually. **I then created the bottom middle, which I felt did this very strongly.** I iterated it slightly further and madde the bottom right, which has a **slightly more dynamic look and emphazises the bird.** I discussed with my peers, and was advised to move forward with the bottom right and have the bottom middle as a solid backup.

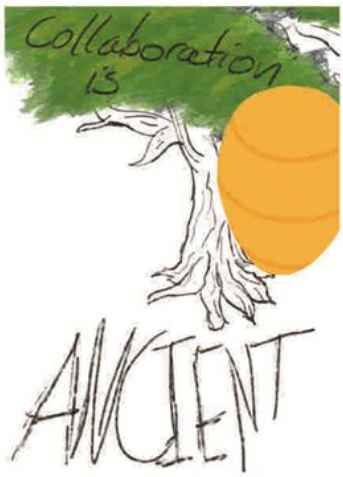
On the third page, **I tried to give a clear line of motion and direction,** and then decided to **re-incorporate the dynamism** I liked from my early sketches. **I decided to do a slight refining to the right one and add a small shrub where a blurb explaining the relationship could go, and then made my final draft iteration to move forward with.**



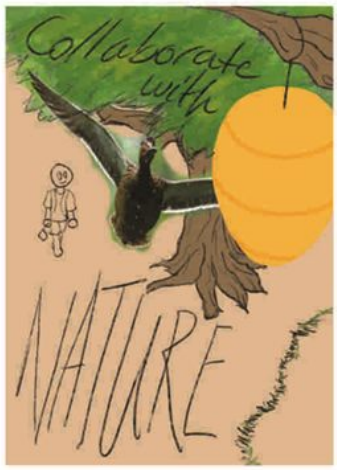


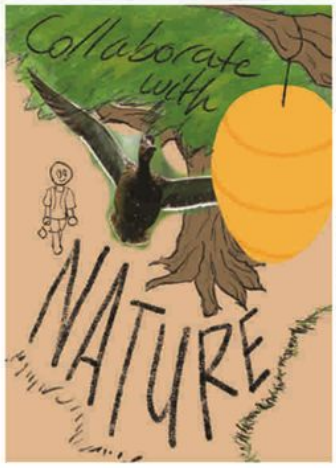


Digital iterations:

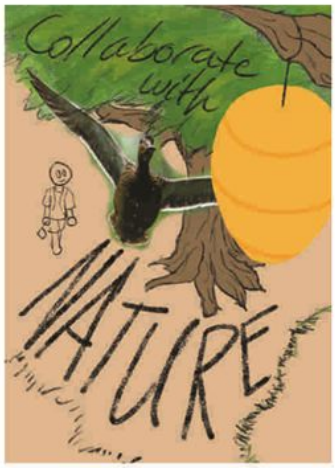


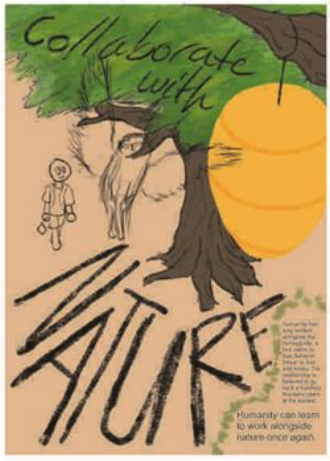




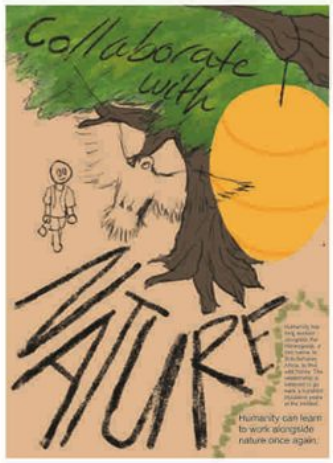


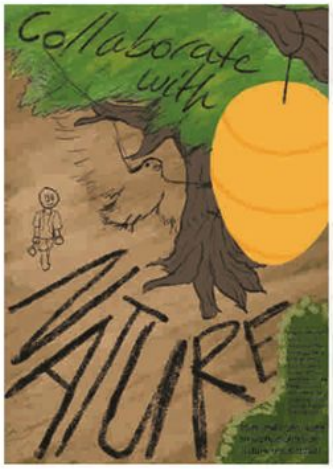
The bird was to visualize what it would end up looking like

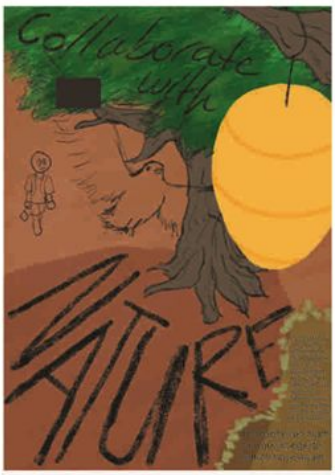


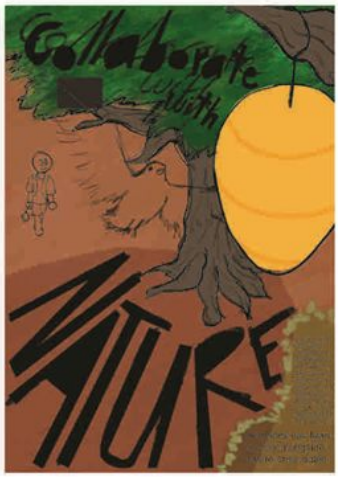












For this bit, I was figuring out the textures I wanted to use, and I really liked the brushes I was using in Affinity. I was also testing out how big the person should be and where to place them in the composition. However, **it all felt rather drab, which I didn't like.** It was also all very similar in terms of colour value, so nothing really stuck out that much. **The text also felt a bit awkward, and while the realistic look was nice, I wanted illustrative, and I felt like there wasn't much joy given in the very realistic ones. But I did like the dynamism being very clear, and it being clear the person was following the bird.** I also switched the message to 'Collaborate with nature', which I felt made the message clearer. However, I did run into trouble due to technical errors with Affinity, so I had to ditch Affinity and recreate it on MediBang.

Digital iterations:



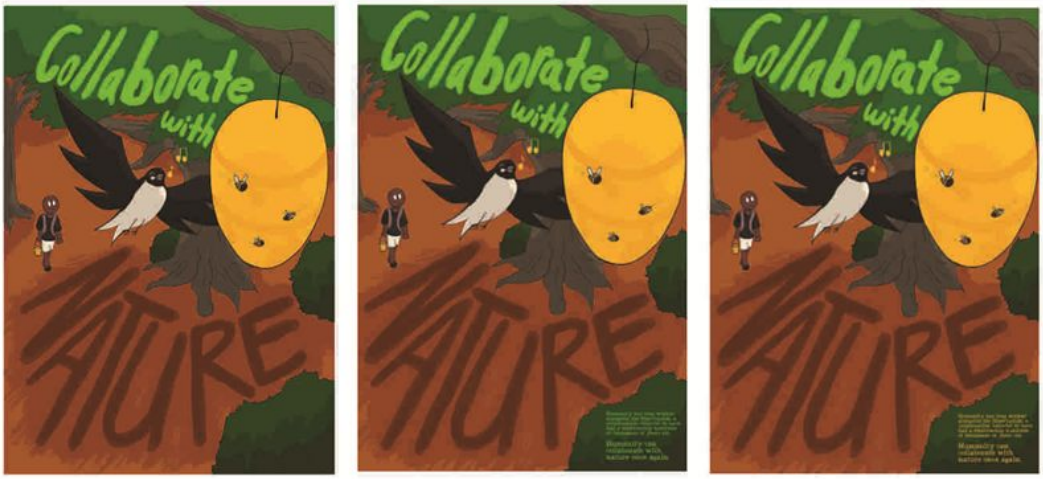
I decided that to emphazise the joy and also lean further into visualising the collaboration, **I changed the eyes of the birds from being dots to happy looking eyes and giving them music notes, reminiscent of how they use a specific call to lead humans to honey.** I also tried moving the heading text around a bit as it felt awkward. I then considered adding more to the enviroment to make the poster richer and also considering a different heading phrases, but I eventually returned to 'Collaborate with nature'. **I quite liked the extra shrubbry and tree.** I was also testing out the eyes for the person a little bit, **but I felt the irises made the person look odd considering the style they're drawn in.**

Digital iterations:



I made sure that there were shared colours between the human and the Honeyguide so I could visually clarify the connection more.

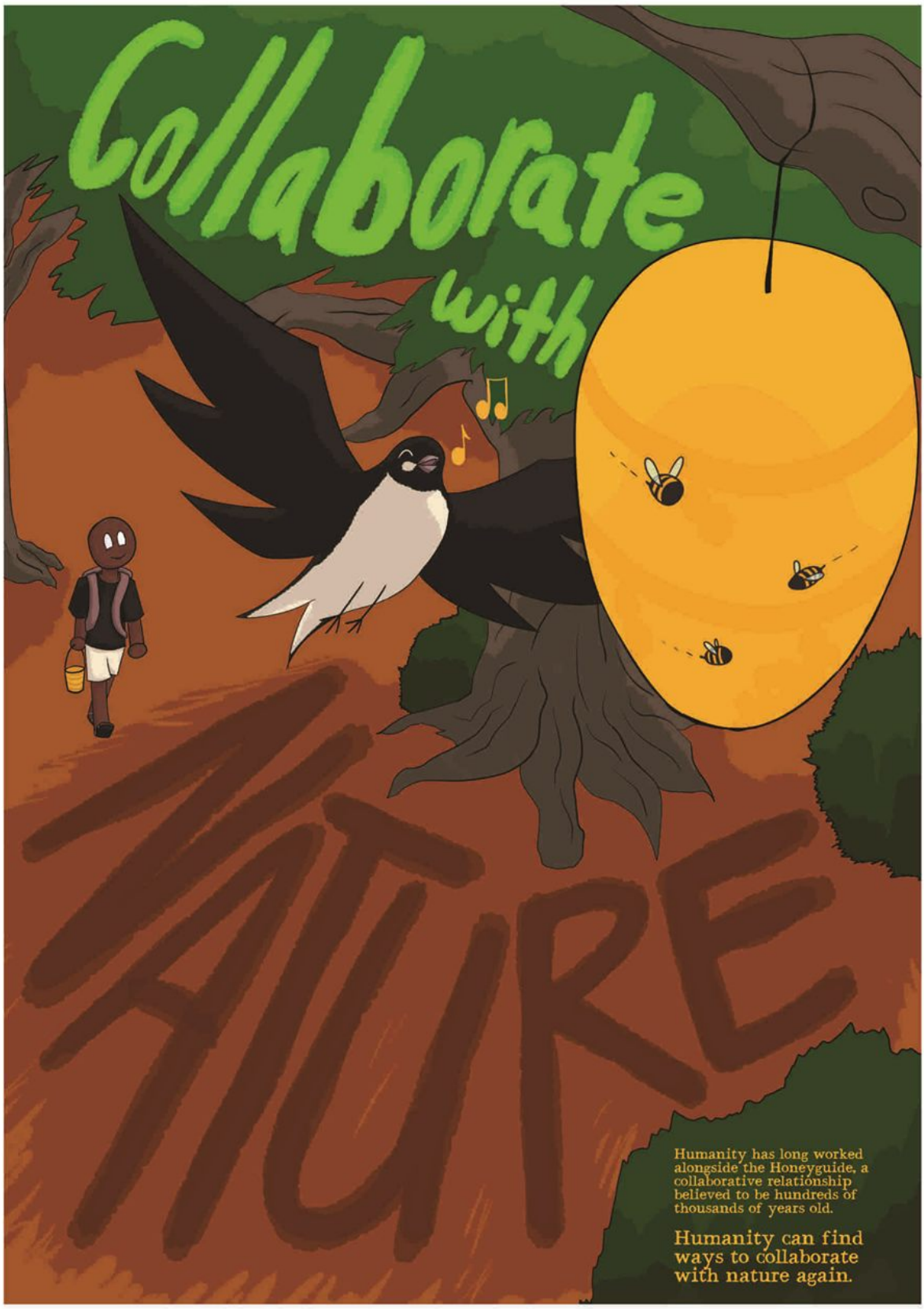




Added white dots to the Honeyguide's cheeks as that's a part of their features. I also made the happy eyes in the Honeyguide the same colour as the fur so it's clearer.

I added in the colours I had made in Affinity, but I still wasn't quite pleased with the look. **I tested out some different shading ideas before settling on a more bushy shading look in comparison to the lines for the shading, tried out more spattered shading, added a bit of texture back to the bark, and messed around with the colour of the typeface,** but I was still unhappy with the colours of the poster as they felt sad and cold, which is the opposite of what I wanted. I was also dealing with some clarity issues. I talked to my tutor and lecturer about these issues, and I got some solutions plus some other tips. **We enriched the palatte to give it a warm colouration by leaning more into yellow-ishgreens and reddening the brown, which really helped in achieving the results I wanted. I also changed the notes from black to yellow so it stands out against the dark green and also to visually connect the song to the beehive, which is what the bird leads people to. I also removed the hatchet as it was noted it could give the impression the person was hunting the bird and switched it out for a bucket. The beehive was also not incredibly clear, so I added some spatterings of honeycomb and a few bees to visually communicate what the bird was flying towards.** I darkened the nature so it made sense in the shade but was still standing out against the shade. I made the yellow in the main hive a bit richer so it could fit in better with the new colours. I bent the 'Collaborate with' so it could appear like it was sitting on the tree leaves, and then I broke up the edges of the shading surrounding 'nature' so it could keep that slight leafy-ness from the edges of the tree leaves. **I decided to make the heading types be slightly painted in appearance so they could feel like they were a part of the enviroment.** I decided to have the body typeface be one that's clear but also feels a bit hand-written to keep with the illustrative style. I tested out using the green from the 'Collaborate with' and the yellow from the beehive, and I chose the yellow as it stuck out more from the bush.

Final poster design:



I believe this poster best demonstrates what I set out to do. It has clear dynamism and action, while also maintaining good asymmetrical balance. I think it also appears charming and joyful, which would hopefully break up the stream of depressing news and allow for young adults to see something more positive and feel a bit more hopeful.

The way I intend for the poster to be read is: You see the happy bird flying towards the beehive and then you see the human happily following the bird. You can visually connect all three, so they must have some relationship to each other. You read the headings and go 'Ah, so they're collaborating together, that's why they're happy! How can that be more commonly done?' Then you read the blurb, learn about humanity's relationship with the Honeyguide, and then go 'Wow, we've done this for ages? Maybe we can do this again!' and then walk away happy and now with the knowledge of humanity's oldest known collaborative relationship - one with nature, and the Honeyguide.

Rationale:

My poster is targeted towards young adults as I believe during this time with all the depressing news it's very easy to feel hopeless, especially young adults as they are the ones who have to bear the burden of it. I wanted to break up that news a little bit with a poster that has a rather joyful message. For this, I used humanity's relationship with the Honeyguide, which has been around for hundreds of thousands of years, potentially predating homosapiens (Rossi, 2026), to show that we can collaborate with nature and that we have for ages.

Since this is a poster about nature, I wanted to use a more illustrative style so it can stand out amongst all the very digital looks. I also wanted to use colours and settings more associated with the environment that the Honeyguide primarily comes from which is Sub-Saharan Africa (Indicatoridae Archives - NatureWorks, 2022).

I wanted to actively show how humanity and the Honeyguide work together, so I decided to make sure my final poster demonstrated this in a visually interesting way while also being readable and showing the connection between the elements. I made the Honeyguide and the person share some colours so that this connection is clear, and I felt like the dynamism allowed for the collaboration to be shown in action.

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